

Political Science Research

Instructor: Li Shao

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Office Hours: 10:00am–11:30am, Tuesday, or by appointment

Political Science is a social science discipline that focuses on explaining political phenomena and issues. In this class, we will briefly introduce some important questions that political scientists study, such as why states are built or fail, why regimes become more democratic or autocratic, why some countries are wealthy while others are poor, and why people vote, protest, or kill each other. Through this class, you will hone your research skills, learn how theories in political science are developed, and hopefully gain a better understanding of politics in the contemporary world.

1 Course Objectives

- Understand some of the important questions, debates, and puzzles that political scientists care about;
- Become familiar with the ways political scientists develop theories and advance knowledge about politics;
- Practice the skills needed to read, analyze, and critique the social science literature;
- Practice academic writing and research skills.

2 Time, Location and Contact

- **Our class time:** Wednesday 8:50–12:25. We will have a 20-minute break at about 10:15am, but you may leave the classroom quietly if you have an emergency.
- **Location:** Zijingang, Graduate School 207
- **Contact:** All communication will be handled via email (shaoli@zju.edu.cn) or through the Dingding group or personal contact (14_2psuasvko3).
I do not accept private WeChat contact. Please note that my reply may not be immediate. Please allow up to 24 hours for a reply (longer on weekends). If you have difficulty contacting me, please do so as early as possible so that you can receive a timely reply.
- **Tronclass** (xuezhai zheda) will be used for the following purposes: attendance, homework upload and return, in-class surveys, and submission of discussion assignments.
- **Our working language is English.** All conversations and communication related to this class will be conducted in English without exception.

3 Assignment and Grading

This class is **reading intensive** and **discussion intensive**. It is not a lecture-style class in which I will do most of the talking (starting from Week 1). Instead, I expect students to contribute to more than 60% of the class discussion.

Our class discussion will be built on the readings assigned each week. You need to demonstrate that you have completed the readings by actively participating in and contributing to class.

Please expect to spend, on average, 3–6 hours per week on readings and assignments for this class. At the same time, I expect you to develop the skills needed to understand academic literature in a time-constrained manner. If you cannot fully understand the papers and books within a limited number of hours, *please move on* and write down the questions you have about specific readings or sections. We will address these questions in class. *There is no dumb question.*

3.1 Grading System

- In-class Participation: 10%
- Discussion Leader: 20%
- Response Paper: 60%
- Research Presentation: 10%

3.2 In-class Participation

In-class participation will be based on your attendance and your performance in class *when you are not serving as a discussion leader*. Your participation includes asking questions and making comments. The more you contribute, the higher your score will be.

Students who are *not* discussion leaders need to submit **three questions** related to that week's readings by *12:00pm Beijing time on Tuesday*.

3.3 Discussion Leader/Group Work

Starting from Week 2, each week we will have one discussion leader group. **Groups will be assigned randomly** by the Tronclass system. Each group will serve as the discussion leader twice during the semester. [The number of students in each group will depend on how many students remain in the class.]

3.3.1 Background Readings

Each discussion leader group will be provided with **at most 15 minutes** to present the background readings.

The presentation should briefly discuss the major arguments of the readings and offer comments or questions about that week's topic. You may focus your presentation and discussion on a few specific readings or on all of the readings assigned for that week. The presentation should help the class review the major arguments and theories in the readings and consider the connections among them, as well as how they address the topic we focus on that week.

At the end of the presentation, each group should also provide five questions for discussion.

Please note that this is group work, so you need to arrange the presenters among yourselves. Usually, only one presenter per group is required.

3.3.2 Key Reading

For this reading, the presentation group needs to present it in detail, not only as readers but also from the perspective of researchers.

You should present it as if you were the author, starting with the motivation for the research, the research question, the theories and hypotheses, the empirical research design, the findings, and the contribution to the literature. By reading and breaking down the paper in depth, you will learn how to conduct research by following the standard procedures used by political scientists and other social scientists.

Your presentation will also be used to elicit discussion. Because you are taking on the role of a researcher, we may stop you at any time if part of your presentation is unclear and ask you to clarify it. All students are encouraged to ask questions if they do not understand the presenter's explanation.

3.3.3 AI Practice

As a way of integrating AI tools into your study, you may choose the AI Practice option for your presentations on the Background Readings and the Key Reading. It involves the following steps:

1. You use AI tools to create presentation slides or notes without human intervention by uploading the reading materials to them.
2. You comment on those slides and notes, correct them, add new content, or remove content if necessary.
3. In your presentation, you need to present the "corrected version," which includes visible marks of correction, usually with different font sizes and colors.
4. You also need to disclose your prompts and the AI models and tools you use.

3.4 Response Paper

Over the course of the semester, each student should submit **three** response papers as brief literature reviews and critical assessments of the following week's readings. You need to analyze differences in the arguments and theories across the readings. Think of the response paper as a written version of your presentation. Your response paper assignments and discussion leader assignments will be scheduled for different weeks.

The purpose of the response paper is to practice your literature review skills. It should go beyond a summary of the readings. You need to discuss the theoretical similarities and debates across the works that interest you, identify a research gap, and explain why this gap is important for future research.

The response paper will be due at midnight on Tuesday, right before class each week. Otherwise, you will lose 5% of your grade per day until it reaches zero.

A typical response paper is 3–6 pages, in 12-point font, double-spaced, with 1-inch margins. However, I do not grade based on length alone. If you get a low score on your first response paper, do not panic. I will also take improvement in your later work into account.

The response paper should be uploaded via Tronclass.

If you decide to use AI Practice to assist with your response paper, you need to submit five papers (except during the two weeks when you are the presenter). You need to provide me with two versions. First, submit a version with revision marks on the AI-generated draft. You also need to explain why you want to revise, add, or remove certain parts generated by AI. Second, provide me with a clean version that you "collaborated on" with AI. Attach the two versions together. Again, disclose your prompts and the AI models and tools you used.

3.5 Research Presentation

To help the class with their master's theses, starting from Week 2, each student will have one chance to present their own project, preferably a master's or doctoral thesis project. You will have **a strict five minutes** to finish your presentation, and up to ten minutes for comments from your classmates and the instructor. Each week we will host two to three students.

In this presentation, you will be treated as a real scholar rather than as a student. The grading criteria include the clarity and brevity of the presentation, the clarity of the research question, your understanding of the literature, the logic of the research design, and the quality of the data analysis. The standard will be higher for students who present after Week 4.

I will not grade this presentation based on how much progress you have already made on the research. Early-stage projects may receive a higher score if they are moving toward a reasonable research question. Late-stage projects may receive a low score if the research design and data analysis are weak. However, if you can clearly explain how you will improve the weaknesses in your research in the future, you can still receive a good grade even if your current project sounds problematic. This is a chance for you to improve your own research, so please use it well.

Citation Style: Use APSA style; <https://mk0apsaconnectbv6p6.kinstacdn.com/wp-content/uploads/sites/43/2018/11/Style-Manual-for-Political-Science-2018.pdf>

3.5.1 Other Announcement on Grading

I do not grade on a curve, in which students compete against each other for a pre-determined number of A's and B's. Rather, I set a standard and grade based on that standard. It is thus possible for everyone in the course to receive an A or for everyone in the course to receive an F. My goal, of course, is for all students to pass. But it is worth noting that *it is possible for students to fail the course*.

I reserve the right to increase grades if a student participates well in class, or if a student shows marked improvement over the course of the semester. I also reserve the right to decrease grades in rare cases if participation is substandard (e.g., not participating in group work, frequently failing to attend classes).

4 Course Materials

I will put all materials on Tronclass. You need to access Tronclass and download them for your reading.

There are three types of readings each week. The first type is the background readings. They usually contain 6–7 papers and book chapters. These readings help us understand the topic and the major arguments. You are asked to skim through the readings as a researcher in order to quickly grasp their main ideas and logic without focusing on the details (unless you want to).

The second type is the Key Reading. Each week I will assign ONE paper that has been published recently online. You need to read it carefully from a researcher's perspective and understand how the authors conducted their research.

Third, I also list supplementary readings for each week if you are interested in reading further. I will not upload the supplementary readings to Tronclass. You will need to find them yourself or ask me whether an electronic copy is available.

5 Academic Integrity

This course has ZERO tolerance for violations of academic integrity. This means that if you are caught, you will receive an F. You need to complete your work independently except in cases of group work. You need to cite properly whenever you use writing that is not your own. You cannot reuse work that you completed previously as homework for this course.

You may use AI-assisted tools such as ChatGPT to help with your writing. However, relying on these tools may also violate academic integrity if most of your work is done by AI rather than by you. LLM-based AI tools also generate mistaken or fabricated results in many cases when they are asked to summarize PDF files or provide academic citations. That said, you will be caught and fail the course if you do not do your own work. Please do your own work first, and then use these tools to improve your writing skills.

6 Reading Instruction

When you read the assigned literature, try your best to answer the following questions in your preview notes:

1. What are the major arguments of these readings?
2. What are the major theories that support these arguments?
3. How do these theories and arguments provide knowledge and answers related to this week's topic?
4. Are these arguments / theories consistent with each other, or contradictory? Think about it from both theoretical and empirical perspectives.
5. Are these arguments or theories convincing? If not, why not? Can you think of better explanations?
6. What have you learned from these readings? What do they tell you about things you did not know before? What do you still not know?

7 Course Schedule

1. **04/28 Introduction to the Syllabus** What is social science theory? What is political science and what are its subfields? How can you read a paper or a book efficiently? **Warming-up reading:** Liu, Sibó, Shouzhi Xia, and Dong Zhang. 2026. "From Maoism to MAGA: Embracing Democracy with Authoritarian Imprints." *Comparative Politics* 58(2): 149–72. doi:10.5129/001041525X17556297089805.
2. **05/06 State Formation and State building**
 - What is a state? What are the conditions to build a strong state?
 - **Discussant:**
 - **Presenters:**
 - **Response Papers:**
 - Key Reading: Wang, Minzhao, Austin Michael Mitchell, and Weiwen Yin. 2025. "Foreign Faith and Rising State: An Examination of State-Building Dynamics in Late 16th-Century Japan." *Political Science Research and Methods*: 1–20. doi:10.1017/psrm.2025.10023.
 - Background Readings:
 1. Tilly, Charles. 1985. "War Making and State Making as Organized Crime." In *Bringing the State Back In*, eds. Peter B Evans, Dietrich Rueschemeyer, and Theda Skocpol.
 2. Fukuyama, Francis. 2013. "Democracy and the Quality of the State." *Journal of Democracy* 24(4): 5–16.
 3. Dincecco, Mark, and Yuhua Wang. 2018. "Violent Conflict and Political Development Over the Long Run: China Versus Europe." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21(1): 341–58.
 4. Centeno, Miguel Angel. 1997. "Blood and Debt: War and Taxation in Nineteenth-Century Latin America." *American Journal of Sociology* 102(6): 1565–1605.
 5. Taylor, Brian D., and Roxana Botea. 2008. "Tilly Tally: War-Making and State-Making in the Contemporary Third World." *International Studies Review* 10(1): 27–56.
 6. Vu, Tuong. 2010. "Studying the State through State Formation." *World Politics* 62: 148.
 7. Suryanarayan, Pavithra. 2024. "Endogenous State Capacity." *Annual Review of Political Science* 27(Volume 27, 2024): 223–43. doi:10.1146/annurev-polisci-061621-08470
 - Supplementary Readings
 1. Chen, Joy, Erik H. Wang, and Xiaoming Zhang. 2024. "From Powerholders to Stakeholders: State-Building with Elite Compensation in Early Medieval China." *American Journal of Political Science* 69: 607–23. doi:10.1111/ajps.12888.
 2. Hanson, Jonathan K., and Rachel Sigman. 2021. "Leviathan's Latent Dimensions: Measuring State Capacity for Comparative Political Research." *The Journal of Politics* 83(4): 1495–1510.
 3. Wang, Yuhua. 2021. "State-in-Society 2.0: Toward Fourth-Generation Theories of the State." *Comparative Politics Online First*: 24.
 4. Fukuyama, Francis. 2014. *Political Order and Political Decay: From the Industrial Revolution to the Globalization of Democracy*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux.
 5. Acemoglu, Daron, and Robinson, James A.. 2019. *The Narrow Corridor: States, Societies, and the Fate of Liberty*. New York: Penguin Press
 6. Scott, James C. 1998. *Seeing like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed*. New Haven: Yale University Press.
 7. Huntington, Samuel P. 2006. *Political Order in Changing Societies*. Yale University Press.
 8. Hui, Victoria Tin-bor. 2005. *War and State Formation in Ancient China and Early Modern Europe*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
 9. Slater, Dan. 2010. *Ordering Power: Contentious Politics and Authoritarian Leviathans in Southeast Asia*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

10. Tilly, Charles. 1992. *Coercion, Capital and European States*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley-Blackwell
11. Mattingly, Daniel C. 2016. "Elite Capture." *World Politics FirstView*: 1–30.
12. Migdal, Joel S. 1988. *Strong Societies and Weak States: State-Society Relations and State Capabilities in the Third World*. Princeton, N.J: Princeton University Press.
13. Wang, Erik H., and Yiqing Xu. 2018. "Awakening Leviathan: The Effect of Democracy on State Capacity." *Research & Politics* 5(2): 2053168018772398.
14. Adams, Julia. 2005. *The Familial State: Ruling Families and Merchant Capitalism in Early Modern Europe*. Cornell University Press.
15. Boone, Catherine. 1998. "State Building in the African Countryside: Structure and Politics at the Grassroots." *The Journal of Development Studies* 34(4): 1–31.
16. Bates, Robert H. 1981. *Markets and States in Tropical Africa: The Political Basis of Agricultural Policies*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

3. 05/13 Democratic System and how it is run

- What is a democracy? What determines the quality of the democratic governance?
- Key Reading: Klüver, Heike. 2025. "Social Influencers and Election Outcomes." *Comparative Political Studies* 58(13): 2973–99. doi:10.1177/00104140241306955.
- Background Readings:
 1. Schmitter, Philippe C., and Terry Lynn Karl. 1991. "What Democracy Is. . . and Is Not." *Journal of Democracy* 2(3): 75–88.
 2. Mainwaring, Scott, and Matthew S. Shugart. 1997. "Juan Linz, Presidentialism, and Democracy: A Critical Appraisal." *Comparative Politics* 29(4): 449–71.
 3. Horowitz, Donald L. 2003. "Electoral Systems: A Primer for Decision Makers." *Journal of Democracy* 14(4): 115–27.
 4. Cleary, Matthew R. 2007. "Electoral Competition, Participation, and Government Responsiveness in Mexico." *American Journal of Political Science* 51(2): 283–99.
 5. Chhibber, Pradeep, and Irfan Nooruddin. 2004. "Do Party Systems Count? The Number of Parties and Government Performance in the Indian States." *Comparative Political Studies* 37(2): 152–87.
 6. Putnam, Robert D., Robert Leonardi, and Raffaella Y. Nanetti. 1994. *Making Democracy Work: Civic Traditions in Modern Italy*. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press. **[Chapter 6]**
 7. Gerring, John, Carl Henrik Knutsen, and Jonas Berge. 2022. "Does Democracy Matter?" *Annual Review of Political Science* 25(1): 357–75.
- Supplementary Readings
 1. Chu, Jonathan A., Scott Williamson, and Eddy S. F. Yeung. 2024. "People Consistently View Elections and Civil Liberties as Key Components of Democracy." *Science* 386(6719): 291–96. doi:10.1126/science.adp1274.
 2. Staniland, Paul. 2021. "Leftist Insurgency in Democracies." *Comparative Political Studies* 54(3–4): 518–52.
 3. Weyland, Kurt. 2020. "Populism's Threat to Democracy: Comparative Lessons for the United States." *Perspectives on Politics* 18(2): 389–406.
 4. Putnam, Robert D., Robert Leonardi, and Raffaella Y. Nanetti. 1994. *Making Democracy Work: Civic Traditions in Modern Italy*. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press.
 5. Putnam, Robert D. 2001. *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*. 1st edition. New York: Touchstone Books by Simon & Schuster.
 6. Cox, Gary W. 1990. "Centripetal and Centrifugal Incentives in Electoral Systems." *American Journal of Political Science* 34(4): 903–35.
 7. Boix, Carles. 1999. "Setting the Rules of the Game: The Choice of Electoral Systems in Advanced Democracies." *The American Political Science Review* 93(3): 609–24.

8. Lu, Jie, and Yun-han Chu. 2021. "Trading Democracy for Governance." *Journal of Democracy* 32(4): 115–30.
9. Shugart, Matthew Soberg, and Stephan Haggard. 2001. "Institutions and Public Policy in Presidential Systems." *Presidents, parliaments, and policy*: 64–102.
10. Tsebelis, George. 2011. *Veto Players: How Political Institutions Work*. Princeton University Press.
11. Calvo, Ernesto. 2009. "The Competitive Road to Proportional Representation: Partisan Biases and Electoral Regime Change under Increasing Party Competition." *World Politics* 61(2): 254–95.
12. Immergut, Ellen M. 1990. "Institutions, Veto Points, and Policy Results: A Comparative Analysis of Health Care." *Journal of Public Policy* 10(4): 391–416.
13. Adams, James, Michael Clark, Lawrence Ezrow, and Garrett Glasgow. 2006. "Are Niche Parties Fundamentally Different from Mainstream Parties? The Causes and the Electoral Consequences of Western European Parties' Policy Shifts, 1976-1998." *American Journal of Political Science* 50(3): 513–29.
14. Jolly, Seth Kincaid. 2007. "The Europhile Fringe?: Regionalist Party Support for European Integration." *European Union Politics* 8(1): 109–30.
15. Lee, Frances E. 2015. "How Party Polarization Affects Governance." *Annual Review of Political Science* 18(1): 261–82.
16. McCarty, Nolan, and Eric Schickler. 2018. "On the Theory of Parties." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21(1): 175–93.
17. Sartori, Giovanni. 2005. *Parties and Party Systems: A Framework for Analysis*. Nachdr. der Ausgabe Cambridge 1976. Colchester: ECPR Press.
18. Lijphart, Arend. 1969. "Consociational Democracy." *World Politics* 21(02): 207–25.

4. 05/20 Democratization

- Why do some countries transition to democracies while others do not?
- **Discussant:**
- **Presenters:**
- **Response Papers:**
- Key Reading: del Río, Adrián, and Masaaki Higashijima. 2025. "Democratic Reforms in Dictatorships: Elite Divisions, Party Origins, and the Prospects of Political Liberalization." *Comparative Political Studies* 58(12): 2682–2717. doi:10.1177/00104140241302772
- Background Readings:
 1. Huntington, Samuel P. 1991. "Democracy's Third Wave." *Journal of Democracy* 2(2): 12–34. *Comparative Politics* 29(4): 449–71.
 2. Boix, Carles, and Susan Carol Stokes. 2003. "Endogenous Democratization." *World Politics* 55(4): 517–49.
 3. Geddes, Barbara. 1999. "What Do We Know about Democratization after Twenty Years?" *Annual Review of Political Science* 2(1): 115–44.
 4. Ross, Michael L. 2001. Does Oil Hinder Democracy? *World Politics* 53(03): 325–61.
 5. Treisman, Daniel. 2020. "Democracy by Mistake: How the Errors of Autocrats Trigger Transitions to Freer Government." *American Political Science Review* 114(3): 792–810.
 6. Houle, Christian. 2009. "Inequality and Democracy: Why Inequality Harms Consolidation but Does Not Affect Democratization." *World Politics* 61(04): 589–622.
 7. Leipziger, Lasse Egendal. 2023. "Ethnic Inequality, Democratic Transitions, and Democratic Breakdowns: Investigating an Asymmetrical Relationship." *The Journal of Politics* 86(1): 291–304. doi:10.1086/726949.
- Supplementary Readings
 1. Inglehart, Ronald. 1988. "The Renaissance of Political Culture." *The American Political Science Review* 82(4): 1203–30.

2. Acemoglu, Daron, and James A Robinson. 2006. *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*. Cambridge; New York: Cambridge University Press.
3. Higashijima, Masaaki, and Yuko Kasuya. 2022. "The Perils of Parliamentarism: Executive Selection Systems and Democratic Transitions from Electoral Authoritarianism." *Studies in Comparative International Development*.
4. Moore, Barrington. 1993. *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy: Lord and Peasant in the Making of the Modern World*. Reprint edition. Boston: Beacon Press.
5. Boix, Carles. 2003. *Democracy and Redistribution*. Cambridge, UK ; New York: Cambridge University Press.
6. Linz, Juan J., and Alfred C. Stepan. 1996. *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation: Southern Europe, South America, and Post-Communist Europe*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.
7. O'Donnell, Guillermo A, and Philippe C. Schmitter. 2013. *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule*.
8. Boix, Carles. 1999. "Setting the Rules of the Game: The Choice of Electoral Systems in Advanced Democracies." *The American Political Science Review* 93(3): 609–24.
9. Luebbert, Gregory M. 1987. "Social Foundations of Political Order in Interwar Europe." *World Politics* 39(04): 449–78.
10. Boix, Carles. 2011. "Democracy, Development, and the International System." *American Political Science Review* 105(4): 809–28. Dahl, Robert A. 1971. *Polyarchy; Participation and Opposition*. New Haven: Yale University Press.
11. Coppedge, Michael et al. 2011. "Conceptualizing and Measuring Democracy: A New Approach." *Perspectives on Politics* 9(2): 247–67.
12. Jensen, Nathan, and Leonard Wantchekon. 2004. "Resource Wealth and Political Regimes in Africa." *Comparative Political Studies* 37(7): 816–41.
13. Bratton, Michael, and Nicholas van de Walle. 1997. *Democratic Experiments in Africa: Regime Transitions in Comparative Perspective*. Cambridge, U.K. ; New York, NY, USA: Cambridge University Press.
14. Haggard, Stephan, and Robert R. Kaufman. 1997. "The Political Economy of Democratic Transitions." *Comparative Politics* 29(3): 263.
15. Bunce, Valerie. 2003. "Rethinking Recent Democratization: Lessons from the Postcommunist Experience." *World Politics* 55(02): 167–92.

5. 05/27 Authoritarian System and How It Is Run

- How do authoritarian regimes maintain their rule? What are the benefits and risks of authoritarian rule? How do autocrats adapt to the challenges of democratization?
- **Discussant:**
- **Presenters:**
- **Response Papers:**
- Key Reading: Zhu, Jiangnan, Steve Bai, Siqin Kang, Juan Wang, and Kaixiao Liu. 2025. "Authoritarian Cue Effect of State Repression." *American Journal of Political Science* 69(4): 1420–34. doi:10.1111/ajps.12916.
- Background Readings:
 1. Magaloni, Beatriz, and Ruth Kricheli. 2010. "Political Order and One-Party Rule." *Annual Review of Political Science* 13(1): 123–43.
 2. Gandhi, Jennifer, and Ellen Lust-Okar. 2009. "Elections Under Authoritarianism." *Annual Review of Political Science* 12(1): 403–22.
 3. Dimitrov, Martin K. 2013. "Understanding Communist Collapse and Resilience." In *Why Communism Did Not Collapse: Understanding Authoritarian Regime Resilience in Asia and Europe*, ed. Martin K. Dimitrov. New York: Cambridge University Press.
 4. Gandhi, Jennifer, and Adam Przeworski. 2007. "Authoritarian Institutions and the Survival of Autocrats." *Comparative Political Studies* 40(11): 1279–1301.

5. Meng, Anne, Jack Paine, and Robert Powell. 2023. "Authoritarian Power Sharing: Concepts, Mechanisms, and Strategies." *Annual Review of Political Science* 26(1): 153–73. doi:10.1146/annurev-polisci-052121-020406.
 6. Xu, Xu. "To Repress or to Co-Opt? Authoritarian Control in the Age of Digital Surveillance." *American Journal of Political Science*
 7. Jiang, Junyan, Tianyang Xi, and Haojun Xie. 2024. "In the Shadows of Great Men: Retired Leaders and Informal Power Constraints in Autocracies." *British Journal of Political Science* 54(4): 1088–1114.
 8. Liu, Hanzhang. 2024. "Meritocracy as Authoritarian Co-Optation: Political Selection and Upward Mobility in China." *American Political Science Review* 118(4): 1856–72. doi:10.1017/S000305542300120X.
- Supplementary Readings
 1. Han, Rongbin. 2026. *Make China Great Again: Online Alt-History Fiction and Popular Authoritarianism*. Columbia University Press.
 2. Guriev, Sergei, and Daniel Treisman. 2022. *Spin Dictators: The Changing Face of Tyranny in the 21st Century*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
 3. Mattingly, Daniel C. 2020. *The Art of Political Control in China*. Cambridge, United Kingdom ; New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
 4. Dimitrov, Martin K., ed. 2013. *Why Communism Did Not Collapse: Understanding Authoritarian Regime Resilience in Asia and Europe*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
 5. Wintrobe, Ronald. 1998. *The Political Economy of Dictatorship*. Cambridge, UK ; New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
 6. Wedeen, Lisa. 1999. *Ambiguities of Domination: Politics, Rhetoric, and Symbols in Contemporary Syria*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
 7. Mesquita, Bruce Bueno de, Alastair Smith, Randolph M. Siverson, and James D. Morrow. 2004. *The Logic of Political Survival*. Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press.
 8. Frantz, Erica, and Natasha Ezrow. 2011. *The Politics of Dictatorship: Institutions and Outcomes in Authoritarian Regimes*. Boulder, Colo: Lynne Rienner Pub.
 9. Wright, Teresa. 2010. *Accepting Authoritarianism: State-Society Relations in China's Reform Era*. Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press.
 10. Svobik, Milan W. 2009. "Power Sharing and Leadership Dynamics in Authoritarian Regimes." *American Journal of Political Science* 53(2): 477–94.
 11. Svobik, Milan W. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
 12. Geddes, Barbara, Joseph Wright, and Erica Frantz. 2018. *How Dictatorships Work: Power, Personalization, and Collapse*. 1st ed. Cambridge University Press.
 13. Levitsky, Steven, and Lucan A. Way. 2010. *Competitive Authoritarianism: Hybrid Regimes after the Cold War*. Cambridge University Press.
 14. Brownlee, Jason. 2007. *Authoritarianism in an Age of Democratization*. Leiden: Cambridge University Press.
 15. King, Gary, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret E. Roberts. 2013. "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression." *American Political Science Review* 107(02): 326–43.
 16. Jiang, Junyan. 2018. "Making Bureaucracy Work: Patronage Networks, Performance Incentives, and Economic Development in China." *American Journal of Political Science* 62(4): 982–99.
 17. Truex, Rory. 2016. *Making Autocracy Work: Representation and Responsiveness in Modern China*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
 18. Pepinsky, Thomas. 2014. "The Institutional Turn in Comparative Authoritarianism." *British Journal of Political Science* 44(03): 631–53.

19. Hanson, Jonathan K. 2018. "State Capacity and the Resilience of Electoral Authoritarianism: Conceptualizing and Measuring the Institutional Underpinnings of Autocratic Power." *International Political Science Review* 39(1): 17–32.
20. Linz, Juan J. 2000. *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes*. Boulder, CO: Lynne Rienner Publishers.

6. 06/03 Democratic Backsliding

- Why some democracies backslide to autocracies?
- **Presenter:**
- **Response Paper:**
- Key Reading: Grumbach, Jacob M. 2023. "Laboratories of Democratic Backsliding." *American Political Science Review* 117(3): 967–84. doi:10.1017/S0003055422000934.
- Background Readings:
 1. Levitsky, Steven, and James Loxton. 2013. "Populism and Competitive Authoritarianism in the Andes." *Democratization* 20(1): 107–36. doi:10.1080/13510347.2013.738864.
 2. Diamond, Larry. 2021. "Democratic Regression in Comparative Perspective: Scope, Methods, and Causes." *Democratization* 28(1): 22–42. doi:10.1080/13510347.2020.1807517.
 3. Berman, Sheri. 1997. "Civil Society and the Collapse of the Weimar Republic." *World Politics* 49(3): 401–29.
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7. 06/10 Politics and Economic Development

- How can politics affect economic development? How do the major theories contest with each other?
- **Presenter:**
- **Response Paper:**
- Key Reading: Ang, Yuen Yuen, Nan Jia, Bo Yang, and Kenneth G. Huang. 2023. "China's Low-Productivity Innovation Drive: Evidence From Patents." *Comparative Political Studies*. doi:10.1177/00104140231209960.
- Background Readings:
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- Supplementary Readings
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8. 06/17 Contentious Politics

- Why do people protest against the state?
- **Discussant:**
- **Presenter:**
- **Response Paper:**
- Key Reading: Albertus, Michael, and Victor Gay. 2025. "State-Building and Rebellion in the Run-Up to the French Revolution." *American Political Science Review*: 1–28. doi:10.1017/S0003055425101342.
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 2. Peña, Alejandro M., Larissa Meier, and Alice M. Nah. 2021. "Exhaustion, Adversity, and Repression: Emotional Attrition in High-Risk Activism." *Perspectives on Politics*: 1–16.
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